# Lesson 09: Thinking and Learning: Discussion, Listening and Reading

*English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology*

*Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 3.1: Discussion; 3.2: Listening-5 Tips to Improve Your Critical Thinking; 3.3: Reading-The Value of Confusion; 16.3: Chapter 3 (audio transcript).*

## In this lesson

You will think about how you learn, watch a TED-Ed talk about a five-step process for critical thinking, and read the article "The Value of Confusion". You will practise following a step-by-step explanation, finding the central ideas and purpose of a text, and reporting the results of studies, which you will need in your psychology course.

## Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Follow a talk that explains a process in numbered steps, and answer detail questions about it.
- Apply a five-step critical thinking process to a real decision.
- Find the central ideas and the author's purpose of an article, with supporting quotations.
- Report a study with "A 2004 study found that …".
- Write a discussion post about your learning resources and what you do when you are confused.

## Key language

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| critical thinking | careful, logical thinking about information before you decide | One particularly effective technique is critical thinking. |
| bias | an unfair preference for or against someone or something | A news report with bias shows only one side. |
| manipulation | controlling or influencing people in a hidden, unfair way | An email that promises you millions may be manipulation. |
| scrutiny / skepticism | very careful examination / doubt, not believing something too quickly | A person who uses critical thinking subjects all available options to scrutiny and skepticism. |
| formulate | create and express something (a question, a plan) carefully | One: formulate your question. |
| assumption | something you believe is true without proof | "What assumptions exist?" |

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| perspective / point of view | a way of seeing a situation | Explore other points of view. |
| sift through | look carefully through a large amount of information | Critical thinking can give us the tools to sift through a sea of information. |
| confusion | the feeling of not understanding | Confusion actually leads to deeper understanding. |
| identity | your sense of who you are | Psychologists call that sense of who you are identity. |
| exploration | trying different groups and values to see what fits | The first step is exploration. |
| commitment | deciding firmly about something | The next step is commitment. |
| self-esteem | how much you value yourself | People who explore more have higher self-esteem later in life. |

## Rules and explanations

### How the talk is organized

- Introduction: every day we make many decisions, and critical thinking can improve our chances of making good ones.
- A five-step process. Each step starts with a number: "One: ...", "Two: ...". Each step has an example (a new diet, an email that promises you millions, a political candidate).
- Conclusion: what critical thinking can and cannot do.
- Number your notes from 1 to 5. For each step, write the step and its example.

### How the reading is organized

- Paragraph 1: confusion is a frustrating feeling.
- Paragraphs 2-3: people, especially students, often hide their confusion.
- Paragraph 4 begins with "But confusion might actually be a good thing." Here the text turns from the problem to the writer's main argument, with evidence from studies.
- Paragraph 5: confusion and identity, then advice for the reader.
- Words like "But" and "However" at the start of a paragraph often mark this kind of turn. Read the sentences after them carefully.

### Reporting research

The reading reports studies in a pattern that you will often see in psychology textbooks:

- A + year + study + past verb (explored, found, showed): "A 2004 study explored six moods that people feel while learning."

- They/scientists + found that + clause: "They found that students who spent more of the lesson confused learned the most."
- The general conclusion is in the present: "Based on these studies, scientists believe being confused is a step to learning."

### Questions about a whole text

- **Central ideas (Part A):** the question says "ideas", so the answer must cover the whole text, not only one part of it.
- **Supporting detail (Part B):** choose the quotation that says the same thing as your Part A answer.
- **Author's purpose:** look at the verb in each option (provide, reassure, encourage, explore). Then read the last paragraph again: what does the writer want the reader to think or do?

### Grammar to notice (Lesson 10)

The reading uses many phrasal verbs (a verb + a small word such as up or out): deal with, make up, end up, figure out, try out, give up. Underline them as you read.

## Practice

**Before you start:** read the discussion questions in the Writing task and think about your answers for two minutes.

**Exercise 1. Listening comprehension.** Watch "5 Tips to Improve Your Critical Thinking" (see Watch online) first, without the transcript. Answer the questions. Then watch again. Read the transcript at the end of the lesson material only after you have answered.

1. What is one advantage of critical thinking? a) It's a process that helps us make only large, important decisions b) It's a process that helps us make only small, unimportant decisions c) It's a process that helps us create hidden issues, bias and manipulation d) It's a process that helps us reveal hidden issues, bias and manipulation
2. What is the first step (of five) in the critical thinking process? a) Gather information b) Apply information c) Formulate questions d) Consider implications
3. When making a decision, what is the main purpose of gathering facts and information? a) To make sure your assumptions are illogical b) To weigh out various options or choices c) To ignore the implications of your choices d) To explore your own perspective and point of view
4. Considering the implications of a decision means: a) Examining its potential outcomes and effects b) Asking questions to determine your goal c) Gathering information to weigh out options (the book prints "weight out") d) Determining whether information is logical
5. How can critical thinking improve your chances of making better choices? a) Critical thinking helps you pick the correct and best choice for all situations b) Critical thinking helps you explore only your own perspective and no others c) Critical thinking helps you examine information and make unreasonable choices d) Critical thinking provides you the tools to sift through complex information logically

**Exercise 2. Reading comprehension.** Read "The Value of Confusion" in the lesson material (5 paragraphs). Then answer.

1. PART A: Which statement best expresses the central ideas of the text? a) Allowing yourself to feel confused is a necessary part of developing your brain and understanding yourself. b) Confusion is more important to intellectual growth than it is to understanding your identity. c) It takes a certain degree of self-confidence and maturity to admit that you don't have all the answers. d) Feeling confused is something that will fade with time and experience as you acquire all of the answers.
2. PART B: Which detail from the text best supports the answer to Part A? a) "No matter what is making us confused, the feeling of not knowing what the answers or solutions are can make us feel useless, stupid, and cause us to worry." (Paragraph 1) b) "Instead of admitting or accepting that they don't have the solution, people sometimes try to pretend they have the answers." (Paragraph 2) c) "Students are often guilty of hiding their lack of understanding. If confused about a topic in school, they might pretend to know the answers." (Paragraph 3) d) "Confusion isn't just an important step to learning in school, it's also important for learning who you are." (Paragraph 5)
3. PART A: Which of the following describes the author's main purpose in the text? a) to provide readers with tools to overcome their confusion b) to reassure readers that it's completely normal to feel confused c) to encourage readers to work through their confusion, rather than avoid it d) to explore why teenagers are more susceptible to confusion than adults
4. PART B: Which quote from the text best supports the answer to Part A? a) "We've all felt confused before, and it can be one of the most frustrating feelings to deal with." (Paragraph 1) b) "As young individuals they can be confused about who they are, and might try harder to behave in a particular way." (Paragraph 3) c) "A 2004 study explored six moods that people feel while learning, including frustrated, bored, and confused." (Paragraph 4) d) "Instead of trying to hide or fight your confusion, try to resolve it by trying new things." (Paragraph 5)

## Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me five questions about the talk '5 Tips to Improve Your Critical Thinking'. Correct my grammar."
- "Give me a decision, for example choosing a new diet or an online course. I will go through the five steps of critical thinking aloud. Tell me if I missed a step."
- "Ask me about the studies in paragraphs 4 and 5 of 'The Value of Confusion'. I will report each one: 'A 2004 study found that ...'. Check my tenses."
- "Ask me the two discussion questions about how I learn. Ask a follow-up question after each answer."

## Read aloud

1. Every day, a sea of decisions stretches /ɪz/ before us.
2. We're bombarded /ɪd/ with so many decisions that it's impossible to make a perfect choice every time.

3. Critical thinking can give us the tools to sift through a sea of information.
4. We've all felt confused /d/ before.
5. Students who expressed /t/ confusion during the lesson did better on the final test.
6. Embrace the confusion and explore different solutions to your problem.
7. Word stress: CRIT·i·cal, ma·nip·u·LA·tion, SCRU·ti·ny, as·SUMP·tion, per·SPEC·tive, con·FU·sion, i·DEN·ti·ty, ex·plo·RA·tion.

## Writing task

**Discussion post.** Write a post of 150 to 200 words that answers these questions:

- What resources do you use to improve your learning? The resources might be on campus, at your home, or on the internet.
- What do you do when you do not understand a topic? What do you do when you are confused about a topic?

Include one idea from "The Value of Confusion" (for example, a study and what it found) and say if it matches your experience.

Then ask your tutor: "Write two short posts as two classmates who answered the same questions." Reply to each post in 2-3 sentences: point out a similarity or a difference, ask a clarifying question, or give your opinion on one of their points.

Checklist:

- I answered all the questions and named specific resources.
- I used the simple present for habits (When I am confused, I usually ...).
- I reported a study with a past verb (found, showed) and a that-clause.
- I gave a reason or an example for each point.
- Every sentence has a subject and a verb, and he/she/it verbs have -s.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

## Watch online

- "5 Tips to Improve Your Critical Thinking" by Samantha Agoos (TED-Ed): https://ed.ted.com/lessons/5-tips-to-improve-your-critical-thinking-samantha-agoos

## Answer key

**Exercise 1**

1. d) (book). The talk says critical thinking can "reveal its hidden issues, such as bias and manipulation".
2. c) Formulate questions (book). "One: formulate your question. In other words, know what you're looking for."
3. b) (book). "Information gathering helps you weigh different options."
4. a) (book). In the example, cheaper gas could cause "a huge surge in air pollution, an unintended consequence".
5. d) (book). "Critical thinking can give us the tools to sift through a sea of information." Option a) is wrong: the talk says "it's impossible to make a perfect choice every time".

**Exercise 2**

1. a) (book). The text covers both learning (paragraph 4) and identity (paragraph 5).
2. d) (book). It names both parts: learning in school and learning who you are.
3. c) (book).
4. d) (book). "Try to resolve it" tells the reader to work through confusion, not hide or fight it.

## My notes